Wilhelm Weber — *Elektrodynamische Maaßbestimmungen*

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Wilhelm Weber, whose electrodynamic measurements do not need to be rescued from German but to be gathered. English translations of all eight major memoirs exist, scattered across the years from 1852 to 2021 and the work of at least five translators and editors, in journal papers and website postings. No single volume bringing them together was found after research. This edition is dedicated to Weber as a body of work, standing in order under its author's name, with every earlier translator properly credited.

The story

Wilhelm Weber's electrodynamic measurements — his *Elektrodynamische Maaßbestimmungen*, the careful determinations of electrical forces by measurement — do not need to be rescued from a language English readers cannot use. They need to be gathered.

That distinction shapes this whole dossier, and it is stated at its head for a reason. This is not an untranslated author. A check found that English translations of all eight major *Maaßbestimmungen* memoirs exist. A memoir, in this older scientific sense, is a substantial paper reporting a piece of research. Weber's eight have

each found an English translator at some point.

The trouble is where those translations live. They are scattered across the years 1852 to 2021, the work of at least five translators and editors, in journal PDFs and website postings. A reader who wants Weber's measurements as a body of work must hunt them down one by one, in different places, in different forms, from different hands. No single volume gathers them.

So the unfinished thing here is not a translation. It is a collection. The completable job is to make one uniform, book-form English *Electrodynamic Measurements*, where the memoirs stand together in order, under their author's name, with every earlier translator properly credited where that translator's work has been consulted.

The work and what survives

The source texts are *Wilhelm Weber's Werke*, volumes 3–4, published by Springer in 1893–94, digitised by Google from Harvard and placed on the Internet Archive.

The census of the memoirs, as recorded here, runs as follows.

The 1846 fundamental-law memoir, in *Werke* III at pages 25–214, has a full English version by Susan P. Johnson, edited by Hecht and Assis, in *21st Century Science & Technology*, in 2007. That version is modern, and it is reference only, not copy-text.

An earlier, public-domain route exists. "On the Measurement of Electrodynamic Forces" appeared in R. Taylor, editor, *Scientific Memoirs*, vol. V, published at London in 1852. The 1871 sixth memoir appeared in *Philosophical Magazine* in 1872.

The seventh memoir, of 1878, on the energy of interaction, was translated by Assis and is free on arXiv. It is modern. A further memoir is in English by G. Gregory, in 2008.

Its English fortunes

English translations of all eight major memoirs exist, as separate sources. No single collected English volume of the memoirs found after research.

That second sentence is the finding of this dossier, and it is deliberately bounded in the same way as the other findings in this collection. It does not say that no such volume could exist anywhere. It says that none was found after research.

Rights, and what completing it would take

The German *Werke* of 1893–94, and the 1852 Taylor translation, are public domain. The 2007–2021 Assis-circle translations are modern works. They are usable as references, not as copy-text, and the point is worth stating plainly: "free PDF online" is not public domain. The licence of each modern translation must be verified before any of its wording is reused.

The collected volume should therefore be built from the public-domain German, and from the public-domain 1852 and 1872 English where it exists. Each memoir is credited to Weber, and prior translators are named where consulted.

Done that way, the result would be a genuine addition, even though every memoir in it is already available somewhere in English. Bringing scattered work into one uniform volume is editorial work of a real kind: it turns a search into a book.

Sources

- https://www.mdpi.com/1893166 (review: all eight memoirs exist in English, eight separate sources)
- http://21sci-tech.21stcenturysciencetech.com/Articles%202007/Weber_1846.pdf (1846 memoir, Johnson/Hecht/Assis)
- https://arxiv.org/abs/2009.09296v2 (seventh memoir, Assis)
- https://philarchive.org/archive/NATTCO-21v1 (Werke III pagination)